

Everything Is a Robot (and Nothing Is)

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Abstract

What is a robot, and who gets to decide? As robots evolve beyond metallic humanoids into drones, inflatable architectures, shape-changing materials, AI agents, and garments, the category itself is breaking apart. Human-Computer Interaction and Human-Robot Interaction are not just responding to this shift, they are actively reshaping it. With its focus on interaction, embodiment, proxemics, aesthetics, and lived experience, HCI offers unique tools to interrogate and redefine the essence of robotics. This two-session workshop brings together researchers, designers, and provocateurs to map emerging definitions, challenge disciplinary boundaries, and build a research roadmap for the future of HCI-driven relational robotics. Together, we will explore what robots are becoming and what they could be when interaction takes center stage.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → *Interaction design theory, concepts and paradigms; HCI theory, concepts and models.*

Keywords

Robots, Interaction, Theoretical foundations

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1 Why This Workshop?

The question “What is a robot?” is increasingly unsettled. Robots are no longer defined by rigid bodies or industrial function. At CHI, we witness this expansion firsthand: inflatable architectural-scale robots invite touch and play [3], therapeutic animal-shaped robots blur the boundaries between biology and technology [1], and AI agents without bodies challenge our notions of presence and agency [17, 27, 29]. New modes of interaction, including kinesics, touch, and emotional attunement, are emerging [7, 9, 18, 20, 22, 24, 26, 28] and materials are evolving, offering robotic opportunities that are soft, ephemeral, and increasingly embedded in the fabric of our everyday lives [5, 6, 10, 11, 16, 21, 25]. These developments create new forms, meanings, and relationships in robotics [2, 4, 8, 23], with the assembly of human bodies and robots in use meaning new priorities for design arise [19]. The shift is also visible across disciplines and research cultures. Engineering conferences now embrace art, dance, and fashion as essential to robotics. IROS 2023 launched a functional fashion competition [14], Robosoft 2025 [13] and ICRA 2025 [12] added arts and photography streams. A trend continuing to gain traction as ICSR make art the central theme for 2026 [15]. This workshop invites participants to engage with these transformations, explore relational and intimate interactions, and identify research directions where HCI can lead in shaping plural, situated, and affective robotic experiences. In particular, we believe two global challenges stand out.

- **Communication Beyond Voice:** While AI has advanced in verbal communication, the nuances of human interaction through gestures and physical embodiment are still largely unexplored. HCI research has the opportunity to investigate how these embodied cues shape relational understanding, social presence, and trust between humans and robots.
- **The Challenge of Relational Robots and Touch:** Building robots that can form genuine connections requires not only technical innovation but also empathy, design sensitivity, and attention to ethics. As robots move physically closer to us, questions of trust, consent, and personal space become crucial.

For HCI, this moment is both a challenge and an opportunity. As robots diversify in form and function, how we design, study, and theorize them must evolve to capture overlooked interactions and foreground human values. Unlike robotics or AI alone, HCI integrates human behavior, ethics, and interaction design, making it uniquely positioned to ensure robots are not only functional but also human-centric and socially meaningful. This workshop invites the CHI community to engage with this evolution. The HCI community uniquely contributes design theory and knowledge that complement the technical emphasis of robotics approaches, offering a more human-centered, designerly perspective. Together, we will question what defines a robot, uncover overlooked interactions, and build a research agenda that pushes boundaries. We want to figure out how HCI can support robot forms and novel experiences no one has yet envisioned.

2 Organizers (alphabetically)

Together, the organizers bring a breadth of expertise and perspectives that uniquely position them to organize this workshop. They span disciplines including HCI and HRI, soft robotics, material science, psychology, neuroscience, dance and performance, digital health, and intimate technologies. Several organizers are pioneers in relational and embodied robotics, while others contribute deep knowledge in sensory design, therapeutic applications, and cultural practices of technology. This mix ensures the workshop will not only address technical innovation but also the ethical, social, and experiential dimensions of human–robot interaction. With established leaders, early career researchers, and creative practitioners, the team balances academic rigor with design experimentation and artistic exploration. Their complementary skills, diverse disciplinary grounding, and strong international representation make them exceptionally well qualified to lead a workshop that pushes the boundaries of how robots are conceived, designed, and studied.

Alice Haynes is a Postdoctoral Research Fellow at KTH Royal Institute of Technology in Stockholm, Sweden. Her work is driven by a deep curiosity about interfaces, the boundaries between people, within ourselves, and between humans and technology. With expertise in engineering, soft robotics, and shape-changing materials, she has recently begun to incorporate Soma Design methods into her approach, foregrounding the body and lived experience in the design of technologies that interface with the body. Her current projects involve exploring body-based interactions with soft robots, from small on-body wearables to large scale expressive robot creatures.

Amy Ingold is a Research Associate in Human-Computer Interaction and Soft Robotics at the University of Bristol. She explores how soft and adaptive robotic materials can reshape interaction and embodiment, and how people come to understand and connect with these emerging forms. Drawing on her interdisciplinary background in psychology, neuroscience, data science and design, her work develops affective and embodied approaches to robotics that emphasize social connection and human values.

Amy Winters is an Assistant Professor at TU Eindhoven, working at the intersection of interaction design, soft robotics, and materials science. Her research explores Material Programming, investigating how programmable and responsive materials such as liquid crystal elastomers, magneto-responsive polymers, and cellulose-based actuators can be integrated into interactive systems that evolve over time and respond reciprocally to human interaction.

Anne Roudaut is a Professor in the Department of Computer Science at the University of Bristol and a leader in Human-Computer Interaction. She heads the Bristol Interaction Group (BIG) and specializes in shape-changing interfaces. Her recent work includes developing giant inflatable robots designed for intimate human interaction, such as robots you can hug, as well as therapeutic robots inspired by horse therapy. Anne drives a highly multidisciplinary research agenda that challenges traditional boundaries in robotics and interaction design.

Ellen Weir is a PhD student from the CDT in Digital Health within the Bristol Interaction Group at the University of Bristol. She is working at the intersection of robotics and digital health, with a focus on designing therapeutic technologies. Her research explores how the principles behind horse therapy can inform the development of robots that support individuals through therapeutic processes, particularly those who have experienced trauma. By studying the unique bond formed between humans and horses in therapeutic contexts, Ellen aims to uncover design insights that can help create robots capable of offering meaningful emotional support and companionship.

Jessica Cauchard is a Professor of Informatics at TU Wien, Austria. She specializes in Human-Centered Computing and Ubiquitous Technologies. She is known for her pioneering work in drone interaction, exploring how flying robots can become intuitive and socially aware companions. Her research spans human-computer and human-robot interaction, as well as intelligent systems more generally, with applications in mobile and wearable computing, as well as in social robotics. Through an interdisciplinary lens, she investigates how intelligent technologies can adapt to human needs in dynamic and embodied ways.

Lisa May Thomas is a contemporary dance artist and Senior Research Associate at the University of Bristol's Centre for Sociodigital Futures. Her work investigates how embodied experiences can inform the design, ethics, and aesthetics of digital environments and interactions. She has extensive experience in dance for screen with award-winning film work shown worldwide and broadcast on BBC and Channel 4. Her PhD studies bridged performance and computer science taking a dance-somatic approach to explore how digital technologies mediate interactions between human and nonhuman bodies using virtual reality in participatory performance.

Madeline Balaam is a Professor in Interaction Design at KTH Royal Institute of Technology whose research focuses on interaction design in relation to touch technologies. A guiding belief that she brings, is that touch is intimate, it can change how we understand, think and feel about ourselves. In response, Madeline and

her team use soma design as an approach to designing technologies which touch the body, and touch the body well. Her work includes explorations of how to touch the body in moments of menstrual pain, through to how to touch intimate parts of the body such as the pelvic floor muscles to bring body awareness and new knowledge.

Zhuzhi Fan is a Research Associate in Human-Computer Interaction at the University of Bristol. His research focuses on developing soft robotic cross-sensory technologies to support visually impaired children. He explores how material engineering can create new forms of interaction, sensation, and devices that enable more inclusive and multisensory experiences, bridging interactions between disabled and non-disabled users.

3 Workshop plan

This 2 sessions workshop is structured to foster open exploration, critical debate, and collective imagination. Through a mix of informal discussion, creative mapping, and speculative design, participants will interrogate and expand what it means to be a robot—and how HCI can shape their future.

Session 1 (90 minutes): Designing Intimate Robots

Goal: Explore relational and intimate robot design and identify factors that influence acceptance.

- (1) **Welcome and Framing (10 min)**
Overview of workshop goals, introduction to relational/intimate robots, and explanation of how session outcomes feed into the research roadmap.
- (2) **Warm-Up Discussion (10 min)**
Icebreaker: participants share experiences or thoughts about robot interactions to set context and get to know each other.
- (3) **Design Activity (30 min)**
Groups of 5-6 participants design a robot that enters the participant's intimate space (non-sexual). Consider movement, form, behavior, and relational cues. Use sketches, materials, or puppeteering to prototype ideas.
- (4) **Testing and Evaluation (30 min)**
Groups test each other's robot designs. Participants observe and judge acceptability, comfort, and relational success. Document interactions and reactions.
- (5) **Debrief and Mapping (10 min)**
Groups share insights. Facilitators synthesize a collective map of features that enable successful robot acceptance.

Session 2 (90 minutes): Roadmap for HCI-Driven Robot Research

Goal: Translate insights from Session 1 into future research directions and HCI priorities.

- (1) **Introduction and Group Formation (10 min)**
Present the collective map from Session 1. Mix participants into new groups for cross-pollination of ideas.
- (2) **Roadmap Development (30 min)**
Each group selects key areas from the map (e.g., technical design, consent, communication, intention, movement). Task:

create a timeline of research directions and key questions for the next 5-10 years, highlighting HCI contributions.

- (3) **Group Presentations (20 min)**

Groups share research roadmap highlights. Facilitators note overlaps, gaps, and emerging themes.

- (4) **Synthesis and Planning Discussion (30 min)**

Open discussion to merge group outputs into a shared roadmap for HCI-robotics research. Identify high-priority research questions and potential collaborations. Discuss next steps, including publications and funding opportunities.

4 Publishing Plans

We plan to produce a workshop position paper summarizing key discussions, maps of robot features, and the research roadmap developed during the workshop. This paper will be made publicly available on arXiv or the CEUR Workshop Proceedings, and submitted for publication in ACM Interactions magazine. Organizers will also encourage participants to submit short follow-up papers or design sketches for inclusion in the proceedings. The goal is to create a citable artifact that captures the state-of-the-art thinking in relational and intimate robot design from an HCI perspective.

5 Accessibility

The workshop will provide live transcription for all talks and group presentations. All slides and materials will be made available in accessible formats (e.g., high-contrast PDFs, screen-reader compatible). Group activities will be structured to ensure all participants can contribute, regardless of physical ability, and organizers will provide guidance for participants who need alternative ways to engage in hands-on sessions.

6 Offline Materials

All presentations, slides, activity instructions, and example materials (e.g., puppet templates or design prompts) will be shared before and after the workshop. Photo and video recordings of group presentations and demonstrations will be made available on a private workshop website for participants who could not attend. The shared roadmap and feature maps from the workshop will also be archived online for long-term reference and follow-up work.

7 After the Workshop

The outcomes of the workshop will include:

- A shared map of features that define relational robots, generated from provocative group discussions.
- A research roadmap highlighting key directions where HCI can lead in relational and intimate robot design, including technical, social, and ethical dimensions.
- A position paper, consolidating insights from the workshop, to be submitted to a public repository.
- A plan for follow-up collaborations and funding opportunities, leveraging the collected ideas and the network of participants.

Organizers will facilitate a community mailing list or Slack channel to maintain discussion and track emerging projects post-workshop.

8 Call for Participation

Robots are no longer confined to rigid, metallic machines performing repetitive tasks. Today, they take diverse and surprising forms: inflatable giants, soft shape-shifters, actuated textiles, therapeutic animal-inspired robots, and intangible AI agents. They mediate emotion, act as social companions, provoke culture, and serve as interfaces to complex AI. As robots diversify, how we design, study, and theorize about them must evolve. This workshop invites the CHI community to critically explore what it means to design relational and intimate robots, and to identify research directions where HCI can lead. The workshop will consist of two interactive 90-minute sessions. In the first, participants will engage in hands-on prototyping and puppeteering exercises to explore relational robot design, focusing on intimacy, trust, and social cues. In the second session, participants will use insights from the first to collaboratively develop a research roadmap, highlighting HCI's unique contributions to this emerging field. Activities include group design, testing, discussion, and roadmap creation. Participants are invited to submit a short position statement or prior work summary to facilitate discussion. All outputs, including maps of robot features, research roadmaps, and workshop position papers, will be published on arXiv or CEUR-WS and ACM Interactions, and materials will be available for offline access. We expect 20-30 participants, including researchers, designers, and practitioners interested in HCI, robotics, and relational interaction.

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